

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART THREE · PEOPLE

CHAPTER 8 · PERFORMANCE

Is great acting becoming someone else, or simply being there?

SUNSET BLVD.

City of God · 2002 · 130 min · dir. Fernando Meirelles, co-directed by Kátia Lund · Portuguese · watch with subtitles on

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

*Two films about young men pulled into violence, and two opposite answers to the oldest argument in acting. In *Joker*, Joaquin Phoenix disappears completely: fifty-two pounds lost, a laugh built to hurt, and the Oscar for the most total transformation of his generation.*

City of God was cast almost entirely with young people from Rio de Janeiro's favelas, most of whom had never acted, trained in a workshop and then asked to improvise rather than recite. One performance is built over months. The other is closer to life.

SUNSET BLVD.

CITY OF GOD

2002 · 130 min · dir. Fernando Meirelles, co-directed by Kátia Lund · Portuguese · watch with subtitles on

Two boys grow up in the same Rio de Janeiro housing project across the 1960s and 70s. One wants to be a photographer. The other wants to run the place.

Why it is on the ballot. Where *Joker* is one actor transforming over months, this is a cast of first-timers who were never asked to become anyone. Most came from neighbourhoods like the one on screen, and the result is some of the most alive acting you will ever see from people who had never been in front of a camera.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

THE CAST CAME FROM WORKSHOPS, NOT AGENCIES

Scouts toured Rio's favelas with VHS cameras, and around a hundred young people were chosen for a workshop run by Kátia Lund and the acting coach Fátima Toledo. Accounts of its length vary from four or five months to a year. Only one professional actor, Matheus Nachtergaele, is in the main cast. The project that grew out of the workshop, *Nós do Cinema*, kept going after the film.

THEY NEVER GOT A SCRIPT

Meirelles: "The boys never got or read a script. In the process of rehearsing, we would start creating the scene, then reshaping the scene, then I would ask them to improvise." The dialogue sounds like people talking because it mostly is.

IT COULD NOT BE SHOT WHERE IT IS SET

Meirelles: "We shot it in the City of God, but we had a terrible night. We were kidnapped by drug dealers and it traumatised part of the crew... we realised that we couldn't shoot in the City of God, so we looked for other communities." Most of the film was made in Cidade Alta and elsewhere.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE OPENING

The chicken

A knife is sharpened, a chicken escapes, and a whole street chases it until a young man with a camera is caught in the middle.

Why it matters: The first two minutes tell you this film runs on energy, not polish. Nobody moves like they have hit a mark. Part of the chase was a genuine accident that the camera simply followed — cinematographer César Charlone: “Let’s say that God is more creative than we are.”

THE APARTMENT

One room, many years

The film tells the history of a single apartment from one position as its owners change, the walls darken and the place decays.

Why it matters: The actors come and go and the room stays. The film is as interested in the place as in any one performer.

THE YOUNGEST KIDS

Watch their faces

The children in the gangs are played by children.

Why it matters: They are not performing menace the way a trained actor would, which is exactly what makes them frightening. One scene involving two small boys is the hardest thing in the film to watch, and it is hard because nobody in it looks like they are acting.

Keep track of when the narrator picks up his camera and what he points it at.

Why it matters: The one character who wants to watch rather than act is the one who survives to tell it. The still photograph that ends his arc was actually taken by Alexandre Rodrigues himself, after the production trained him on the camera.

03

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

The end credits show the real people

The film closes with television news footage of the real man one of the characters is based on, interviewed in jail. It is a jolt, and it tells you how close the cast stood to the story.

OPEN

Four Oscar nominations, a year late

Released in Brazil in 2002, it was Brazil's submission for Best Foreign Language Film and was not nominated. Its delayed American release made it eligible the following year, when it took four nominations — Director, Adapted Screenplay, Cinematography and Film Editing — and won none.

OPEN

What happened to the cast is a mixed story

Alexandre Rodrigues and Leandro Firmino both kept working — Firmino won Best Actor at the Havana festival and has had a continuous Brazilian screen career; Rodrigues has worked steadily in film, television and theatre, with more recognition abroad than at home. Most of the wider cast did not get the same chances.

01 Could you tell which actors were professionals? Does it matter?

02 Phoenix researched Arthur for months. Some of this cast had lived closer to their story than any actor could research. Which is “more real”?

03 What does a film gain, and lose, by casting people instead of actors?

Where to watch

Find it here → [City of God on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: BFI · Sight and Sound · Roger Ebert · Big Picture Film Club

THE LESSON

FEEL IT FOR REAL

A RUSSIAN DIRECTOR DESCRIBED A SYSTEM

Konstantin Stanislavski, co-founder of the Moscow Art Theatre, spent decades writing down how his actors worked: imagining the character's circumstances, finding an objective in every scene, sometimes drawing on their own memories. *An Actor Prepares* reached English readers in 1936 — as a single volume he had never intended, since he meant it and *Building a Character* to be one book. He kept revising the system for the rest of his life.

AN AMERICAN TEACHER MADE IT THE METHOD

In New York, Lee Strasberg took one piece of that system, affective memory, and made it the centre of a technique. As artistic director of the Actors Studio from 1951 he shaped a generation of Studio actors, among them James Dean, Paul Newman and Al Pacino. In his words: "The two areas of discovery that were of primary importance in my work at the Actors Studio and in my private classes were improvisation and affective memory."

THE ARGUMENT STARTED IMMEDIATELY

Stella Adler spent five weeks studying with Stanislavski in Paris in 1934 and came back reporting that he had moved on: actors should build emotion from the given circumstances of the scene and from imagination, not by digging up their own grief. She and Strasberg taught opposing schools for the rest of their careers. The rule that grew out of Strasberg's version — real acting means real feeling, and the proof is transformation — is still roughly how the Oscars vote.

THREE WAYS TO GIVE A PERFORMANCE

ONE

TRANSFORM

The actor rebuilds body, voice and mind to become someone else.

Raging Bull · There Will Be Blood · Joker

TWO

BE PRESENT

Non-professionals cast for who they are and allowed to behave rather than perform.

Bicycle Thieves · The Florida Project · City of God

THREE

BE A STAR

The actor brings the same persona to every role and the film uses it.

Cary Grant · Tom Cruise · Keanu Reeves

None of the three is cheating. The question is which one the film needed.

BEND THE LINE

Lay the ways of putting a person on screen along a line, from the most made to the least: an actor who rebuilds himself entirely, an actor stretching outside his usual register, an actor who brings the same self to every part, and someone who was never trained at all. Most films live in the middle, and none of these is the right answer. Then bend the line.

BECOMING

BEING



Four ways to put a person on screen, from the most made to the least. Bend the line and the two ends meet: all four are after the same thing, getting rid of whatever feels false.

THE METHOD

Rebuilds body, voice and mind until there is nobody left in there to find.

STRETCHING

A trained actor reaching outside their usual register, still recognisably themselves.

THEMSELVES

The same person in every part, and the film is built to use exactly that.

THE NON-ACTOR

Never trained, cast because they already are what the part needs.

Not all acting requires an actor to disappear, and most of it does not. But when a film wants you to believe a character completely, what it needs is authenticity. Sometimes a director finds it by casting someone who already embodies the role's reality. More often it comes from an actor finding the exact point where their own emotional truth meets the character's fictional one. The goal is not to destroy the self, and not to copy reality. It is to eliminate anything that feels fake.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

Neorealism: the Italian postwar movement that shot in real streets with non-professional actors. *Bicycle Thieves* (1948) cast Lamberto Maggiorani, a factory worker, as its lead — and then he was laid off from the factory, never built a career, and ended up in bit parts. *City of God* is one of that movement's great descendants, and it raises the same question about what happens to people after the film.

WHY THESE FILMS

Chapter 7 was the character on the page. This chapter is the person who has to become it on screen, and the old argument about how. Joker is the Method at its most extreme. City of God asks whether you need acting at all.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the BFI, Sight and Sound, Time Out, IndieWire, Variety, Roger Ebert and the Academy's records. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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